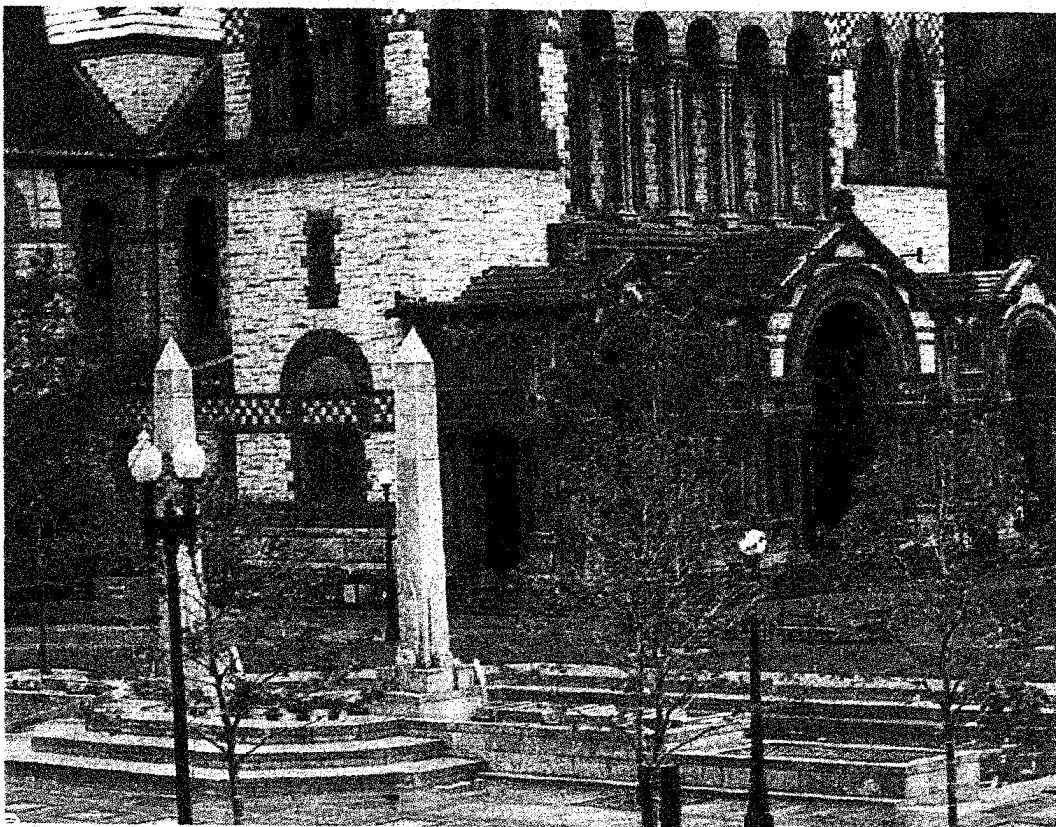


The newest Copley Square is better, but...

Robert Campbell Globe Correspondent

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Globe staff photo/David L. Ryan

The redesigned Copley Square.

architecture

The newest Copley Square is better, but . . .

By Robert Campbell
Globe Correspondent

How quickly the pendulum of taste swings in architecture. Once again, there's a brand new Copley Square. It replaces the Copley Square that was brand new in 1968. And, where the 1968 square failed because it was too brash, the 1989 square falls well short of ideal because it is too timid.

We're always over-reacting to the mistakes of the past. Pretty much everyone hated the '68 square. Its designers seemed to be trying to insert the dramatic paved terraces of an Italian hill town into the middle of Boston. The '68 square was an architect's design, not a people's design. It looked groovy in an artist's rendering. But it didn't work.

So now we've over-reacted. To walk through the new Copley Square, which opens officially on June 22, is to wonder whether there was any designer at all this time around. If the '68 hill town square was too strong an idea, the new square lacks any central idea at all.

All the elements of the new Copley Square seem to be arranged more or less at random. A shapeless patch of grass here, some patterned paving there, a

fountain that is bombastic in concept but chintzy in execution, some trees, some benches, all more or less helter-skelter.

Most oddly of all, and most revealingly, there is a monument to the schlock philosopher Kahlil Gibran. It is modest in size but is so prominently positioned that if you didn't know better you would assume you were in Gibran Square. In the city of Emerson and Santayana and William James, giving this kind of attention to a purveyor of best-selling third-hand brain-fuzz is carrying populism a little too far.

Mayor Raymond Flynn, when he announced the winning design back in 1984, said it all: "The winning design by landscape architect Dean Abbott conveys a message that Copley Square is an interaction of neighborhoods, not a symbol or monument."

No doubt that kind of statement is good politics. But it isn't always good design. Shouldn't a prominent square have its own sense of place? Its own specialness? Should it be nothing but a big cross-roads in the city? Shouldn't there be, in Gertrude

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Copley Square better, but . . .

■ ARCHITECTURE

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Stein's immortal words, a THERE there?

I don't want to be too harsh. There is no question that the new Copley Square is a big improvement on the '68 square. That earlier design — the winner of a quite famous design competition — suffered from grave defects. It was isolated from the streets around it because much of it was sunk below grade behind concrete berms. The isolation was intended to make it feel like a refuge from the congested city; instead, the square felt cut off and unsafe. And it was executed in cheap materials, notably asphalt tiles, that made it seem cheesy. Finally, it was not well maintained.

The new square — the winner of a competition in which 309 designs were submitted in 1984 — corrects all those problems. It's flat and accessible, neither sunk-en nor raised. It's paved in handsome brick and granite, with fine benches and big new trees. And it possesses an endowment, privately raised, for future maintenance. The Copley Square Centennial Committee, which sponsored the competition, intends to remain in existence to monitor that maintenance. How important that monitoring will be is already obvious. Because maintenance hasn't yet begun, the new square and its

fountain are already littered with junk of all kinds.

Many of these improvements can be traced to a single source. For the last 15 years or so, the writer William Whyte has been studying American public spaces — streets and squares — to find out which ones work and why. He concludes that while people often say they want a refuge from the city, their actions prove they really want to be near the thick of things. Good spaces aren't isolated. They have plenty of seating. They have a choice of sun or shade. They usually have some kind of food service. And they are level enough with the city around them to allow clear vision both ways.

Whyte was one of the jurors in the latest Copley Square competition. Even before that, his ideas were prominent in the description of goals for the future square that went out to prospective competitors. Thus, it's likely that the new square will function a lot better than the old. It's going to be allowed to be a little messy, for instance, with a Farmer's Market every week or so. With luck, it will sprout some food vendors and even, perhaps, a few peddlers and entertainers — although one has to worry whether the chief sponsors, who include the obsessively security-conscious John Hancock Insurance Co., will really permit that kind of genuine street life.

Some things have changed from the original winning proposal by Dean Abbott of the firm of Clark & Rapuano, landscape architects in New York. There are fewer trees, for example, apparently in an effort to preserve unbroken views of some of the architectural landmarks that surround the square — the Boston Public Library, the new Old South Church and Trinity Church. This is a mistake and the square would be better with more trees. Parts of it feel too open and barren. The fountain, which Abbott placed where it supposedly could reuse the equipment from a previous fountain, has now been greatly elaborated in a way that is stagey and self-conscious.

I don't want to rehash the competition judging. Yet, it's instructive that nearly every designer I know thought the second-prize proposal for Copley Square was

better than the winner. It was designed by a Harvard-based team of Kristen Osterby-Benson, Peter Schaudt, Michael R. Van Valkenburgh and John Whiteman. It was similar to the winner in many ways but with a crucial difference. It had an unforgettable, imagable sense of place. This was created largely by the invention of a big square of grass, raised 20 inches above the surrounding paving and framed with a sittable granite wall. Without interrupting anyone's easy pedestrian flow through the square, this symbolic town green made Copley Square unique and memorable, in the same way that the duck pond makes the Public Garden unique.

Great public squares need their own character. Otherwise, they are merely in-between space. Copley Square looks too much like a potpourri of too many small ideas in search of a big one. As has been true for a century, it continues to suffer from an identity crisis.

Sometimes there are places in a city that seem cursed, that seem fated never to find their true form. Columbus Circle in New York is like that. So is Copley. As long ago as 1893, the following appeared in a magazine called "American Architect and Building News":

"The Boston Society of Architects takes a most unusual but very praiseworthy and publicspirited step in undertaking to conduct a public competition . . . for the purpose of discovering the best way of rearranging and embellishing Copley Square."

We've been rearranging and embellishing Copley Square ever since. We haven't solved it yet, but at least we're still trying, and it's definitely getting better. For that, we should be grateful. Still, this latest competition seems, once again, to have been a lost opportunity for a great public space in Boston.